

Customer Operations Support Manual

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Owner: Customer Operations **Review Frequency:** Quarterly

1. Purpose

This manual defines how automated and human customer operations systems should investigate customer issues and determine appropriate next actions.

The system should prioritize accurate investigation, policy compliance, and clear escalation.

2. Investigation Workflow

For an operational issue, the agent should generally follow this sequence:

Step 1 — Identify the Issue

Determine the primary issue category:

* Delivery delay * Missing shipment * Damaged product * Incorrect product *
Return request * Refund request * Warranty issue * Payment issue

Step 2 — Retrieve Relevant Records

Retrieve available:

* Order information. * Shipment information. * Customer information. *
Previous support records when available.

Step 3 — Determine Whether Policy Applies

If the issue is governed by a company policy, search the policy knowledge base.

The policy knowledge base should be treated as the source of truth for company-specific rules.

Step 4 — Evaluate the Evidence

Compare the available operational information with the retrieved policy.

The agent must distinguish:

* Known facts. * Retrieved policy requirements. * Missing information. *
Recommendations.

Step 5 — Determine the Next Action

Possible actions include:

* Continue monitoring. * Contact carrier. * Contact customer. * Create support
ticket. * Request additional information. * Escalate to human review. * Take
no action.

3. Source-of-Truth Rules

The agent should use the following priority:

1. Current operational database records.
2. Current carrier information.
3. Approved company policy documents.
4. Previous support records.
5. General model knowledge.

General model knowledge must not override an explicit company policy.

4. Missing Information

Missing information is itself an operational signal.

Examples:

* Missing tracking number. * Missing shipment status. * Missing customer information. * Missing order record. * Conflicting order information.

The agent should not fill missing information using assumptions.

If missing information prevents a reliable decision, escalate.

5. Contradictory Information

If two sources disagree:

Example:

“text Order system: Status = Shipped

Shipment system: Status = Delivered “

The agent should not select one value arbitrarily.

Instead:

1. Identify the conflict.
2. Determine whether a more authoritative source exists.
3. If the conflict cannot be resolved, escalate.

6. Severity Classification

LOW

Use when:

* Issue is minor. * No urgent intervention is required. * Required information is available. * Normal automated handling is sufficient.

MEDIUM

Use when:

* Issue requires monitoring. * Customer impact exists. * A standard operational action is recommended.

HIGH

Use when:

* Significant customer impact exists. * Shipment is substantially delayed. * Important operational information is missing. * Carrier intervention is required.

CRITICAL

Use when:

* There is a significant unresolved operational failure. * Multiple systems contain conflicting information. * The issue may affect multiple customers. * Immediate human intervention is required.

7. Human Escalation

Human review is required when:

* The appropriate action cannot be determined confidently. * Policy documents conflict. * Operational records conflict. * Required information is unavailable. * The customer requests an exception. * The case involves monetary authorization. * The case involves a potentially lost or damaged shipment. * The automated agent reaches its maximum tool-call limit.

8. Customer Communication Rules

Customer messages must be:

* Accurate. * Concise. * Based on verified information. * Clear about next steps.

The agent must not:

* Invent information. * Make unsupported promises. * Claim that an action was completed when it was only recommended. * Guarantee delivery dates. * Guarantee refunds. * Claim human approval that has not occurred.

9. Customer Message Structure

When appropriate, a customer message should contain:

1. Acknowledgment of the issue. 2. Verified current status. 3. Next step. 4. Expected follow-up where known.

Example structure:

> We're sorry for the delay. Our latest shipment information shows that your order is still in transit. We're reviewing the shipment and will provide an update once additional information is available.

The exact wording should depend on the available evidence.

10. Tool Usage

The agent should use tools when information is required to make a decision.

Examples:

Order Tool

Use when:

* Order status is unknown. * Customer ID is needed. * Product information is required.

Shipment Tool

Use when:

* Delivery status is unknown. * Tracking information is required. * Shipment delay needs investigation.

Customer Tool

Use when:

* Customer identity needs verification. * Customer contact information is required by an authorized workflow.

Policy Search Tool

Use when:

* A company rule is relevant. * The correct action depends on a policy threshold. * The agent needs to determine eligibility or escalation requirements.

11. Tool Call Limits

The automated agent should avoid unnecessary tool calls.

If the agent cannot reach a reliable decision within the configured maximum number of tool iterations, it should stop automated investigation and escalate.

The agent must not continue indefinitely.

12. Policy Retrieval Failure

If a policy search returns no relevant information:

* Do not invent a policy. * Do not assume the company follows general industry practice. * Determine whether a safe operational action exists. * Escalate if policy information is required.

13. Evidence Requirements

Operational decisions should be supported by evidence.

Evidence may include:

* Order record. * Shipment record. * Customer record. * Retrieved policy document. * Carrier status.

The final decision should identify the important evidence used to reach the recommendation.

14. Automated Action Restrictions

The investigation agent is authorized to:

* Read operational information. * Search policies. * Classify issues. * Recommend actions. * Draft messages.

The investigation agent is not authorized to:

* Modify database records. * Issue refunds. * Modify shipment records. * Change customer information. * Declare shipments lost. * Send external communications without authorization. * Override company policy.

15. Escalation Explanation

When escalating, the agent should provide:

* Issue summary. * Severity. * Evidence reviewed. * Relevant policy. * Missing or conflicting information. * Recommended human action.

A human operator should be able to understand why escalation occurred without repeating the entire investigation.

16. Final Decision Principle

The automated operations system should optimize for:

Accuracy → Policy compliance → Customer clarity → Operational efficiency

When these goals conflict, the system should prioritize accuracy and policy compliance over automation.